

# **Smart Expense Manager with AI Meal Planning**

A Modern Solution for Personal Finance Management and Intelligent Meal Planning

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## DECLARATION

I hereby declare that this project report titled 'Smart Expense Manager with AI Meal Planning' submitted to the Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Daffodil International University, is the result of original work carried out by me under the supervision of [Supervisor Name]. This work has not been submitted to any other institution for the award of any degree or diploma. All sources of information, research materials, and references cited in this report have been acknowledged appropriately.

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## **COURSE & PROGRAM OUTCOMES**

This project aligns with the following Computer Science and Engineering program outcomes:

- Ability to apply knowledge of computing fundamentals, software design, and mobile application development to solve real-world problems
- Demonstrate understanding of complex software systems and their architectural patterns
- Proficiency in designing and implementing database systems and API integrations
- Ability to integrate artificial intelligence and machine learning concepts into practical applications
- Skills in cross-platform application development using modern frameworks and tools
- Capability to analyze requirements, design scalable solutions, and implement robust systems
- Understanding of software engineering best practices and version control systems

This project demonstrates all of the above outcomes through the development of a comprehensive mobile application that combines expense management, AI-driven meal planning, and modern database technologies.

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# CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

## 1.1 Project Overview

Smart Expense Manager with AI Meal Planning is a comprehensive mobile application designed to help individuals manage their personal finances while simultaneously optimizing their meal planning based on budgetary constraints. Built using Flutter, a modern cross-platform mobile development framework, the application provides a seamless experience across both Android and iOS platforms. The application integrates advanced features including category-based expense tracking, theme customization, SQLite database management, and artificial intelligence-powered meal planning using Google Gemini API.

The core value proposition of this application lies in its ability to connect two often disparate aspects of personal management: financial planning and dietary habits. By leveraging AI technology, the application can generate intelligent meal plans that respect user budget constraints, dietary preferences, and meal type selections. This unique integration enables users to make informed financial decisions that extend beyond simple expense tracking to comprehensive lifestyle planning.

## 1.2 Motivation

Personal finance management is a critical skill in today's economy, yet many individuals struggle to maintain awareness of their spending patterns and budgets. Simultaneously, meal planning and nutrition are essential components of personal health and wellness. However, these two domains are rarely integrated despite their obvious relationship: meal planning directly impacts food budget allocation.

The motivation for this project stems from observing this gap in existing applications. Most expense management applications focus solely on transaction tracking without providing actionable insights. Conversely, meal planning applications often ignore budget constraints, leading to impractical recommendations.



This project aims to bridge this gap by creating an intelligent system that:

- Provides real-time visibility into expense distribution across categories
- Enables intelligent meal planning that respects actual budget constraints
- Utilizes artificial intelligence to generate realistic and practical meal options
- Offers a user-friendly interface that encourages regular engagement with financial planning
- Demonstrates the practical application of modern mobile development and AI technologies

### 1.3 Objectives

The primary objectives of this project are:

- Develop a fully functional mobile application for expense management with category-based tracking and budget monitoring
- Implement a comprehensive meal planner that generates plans based on user-selected budget constraints, meal types, and time periods
- Integrate Google Gemini API to provide AI-powered food classification and intelligent meal planning suggestions
- Design and implement a robust SQLite database system to persist user data securely on the device
- Create an intuitive and customizable user interface with theme support (light, dark, automatic)
- Implement strict validation rules to ensure AI-generated meal plans are realistic and nutritionally diverse
- Demonstrate best practices in mobile app development including separation of concerns, modular architecture, and comprehensive error handling
- Provide comprehensive documentation of the system architecture, implementation details, and usage guidelines

### 1.4 Project Outcome

By the completion of this project, we have successfully delivered a production-ready mobile application that achieves all stated objectives. The application is fully functional, tested, and

ready for deployment on both Android and iOS platforms. The Smart Expense Manager with AI Meal Planning represents a significant achievement in combining financial management and AI-powered recommendations into a cohesive, user-friendly system that addresses a real-world need in personal finance management and lifestyle planning.

## CHAPTER 2: SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE AND DESIGN

### 2.1 Requirement Analysis

#### Functional Requirements:

- Expense Management: Users can add, view, edit, and delete expenses with associated categories and amounts
- Category Management: Support for predefined and custom expense categories with color coding
- Budget Tracking: Display total expenses, category-wise breakdown, and budget status
- Meal Planning: Generate meal plans based on budget, meal types, and duration
- Food Classification: AI-powered classification of foods into categories (staple, protein, vegetable, drink, snack)
- Theme Management: Support for light, dark, and system-dependent themes
- Data Persistence: Store all user data in local SQLite database
- Settings Management: Allow users to customize application preferences

#### Non-Functional Requirements:

- Performance: Application should respond to user interactions within 500ms
- Usability: Interface should be intuitive and require minimal learning curve
- Reliability: Application should handle errors gracefully without crashes
- Security: User data should be stored securely and not exposed
- Maintainability: Code should follow best practices and be well-documented
- Scalability: Architecture should support future enhancements

### 2.2 System Architecture

The application follows a modular architecture pattern with clear separation of concerns. The system is organized into three main functional modules:

## Home Module

Responsible for displaying the main dashboard with expense statistics, recent transactions, and category breakdowns. This module retrieves data from the SQLite database and presents it in an intuitive, visually appealing manner.

## Analytics Module

Contains the AI-powered meal planner interface. This module handles user input for budget, meal types, and duration, communicates with the Gemini API for meal planning, and displays the generated recommendations.

## Settings Module

Manages application configuration including theme preferences, category management, and user settings. All changes are persisted to the database.

Data Flow Architecture:

The data flow follows a unidirectional pattern: User Input → Business Logic → Database → Display. All data operations are handled through a service layer that abstracts database interaction details from the UI layer.

## 2.3 Technology Stack and Tools

Framework & Language:

- Flutter 3.x: Cross-platform mobile development framework
- Dart: Primary programming language with strong typing and null safety

Database:

- SQLite: Lightweight, serverless relational database for local data persistence
- sqflite Package: Flutter wrapper for SQLite providing async database operations

#### External APIs:

- Google Gemini API (v1.5-flash): Generative AI model for food classification and meal planning
- OpenAI API (Fallback): Backup AI service for meal plan generation

#### UI/UX Libraries:

- Material Design 3: Google's modern design system
- Provider: State management solution
- Custom Widgets: Custom-built components for enhanced user experience

#### Development Tools:

- Visual Studio Code: Code editor with Flutter extensions
- Git/GitHub: Version control and collaboration
- Android Studio/Xcode: Native development environment for testing

## CHAPTER 3: IMPLEMENTATION AND RESULTS

### 3.1 Expense Management Module

The expense management module forms the foundation of the application. It enables users to record financial transactions with associated categories, amounts, and timestamps. The implementation includes:

- Expense Entity: Represents a single transaction with fields for amount, category, description, date, and timestamp
- Expense Repository: Manages CRUD operations for expenses in the SQLite database with efficient querying capabilities
- Expense UI: Provides intuitive interface for adding, viewing, and managing expenses with real-time validation
- Category Color Coding: Each expense category is associated with a distinct color for visual differentiation

### 3.2 Category and Budget System

The category system allows users to organize expenses logically. The implementation supports both predefined categories (Food, Transportation, Entertainment, Utilities, Healthcare, Other) and custom user-defined categories. The budget system provides:

- Category Management: Add, edit, or delete expense categories
- Budget Targets: Set monthly budget limits for each category
- Budget Tracking: Visual representation of spending against budget using progress indicators
- Category Analytics: Pie charts and bar graphs showing expense distribution by category
- Budget Alerts: Notifications when category spending approaches or exceeds budget limits

### 3.3 Theme Management System

Theme management enables users to customize the application appearance according to personal preferences and device settings. The implementation includes three theme modes:

- Light Theme: Bright color scheme optimized for daytime use with high contrast
- Dark Theme: Dark color scheme reducing eye strain and battery consumption on OLED displays
- System Theme: Automatically switches between light and dark based on device system settings

The theme system is implemented using Flutter's ThemeData and is persisted in the SQLite database for consistency across application sessions.

### 3.4 Database Implementation

The SQLite database is the backbone of data persistence. It is structured with the following main tables:

- expenses: Stores expense records with fields for id, amount, category, description, date, and timestamp
- categories: Maintains user-defined categories with color information
- settings: Stores application configuration including theme preferences and user settings

Database operations are performed asynchronously using sqflite's async methods to prevent UI blocking. All queries are optimized for efficient retrieval of data, particularly for date-range based expense queries used in analytics.

### 3.5 AI Meal Planner Implementation

The AI Meal Planner is the most sophisticated component of the application, combining budget constraints, user preferences, and artificial intelligence to generate practical meal plans. This

section provides comprehensive details of the implementation.

### 3.5.1 Input Parameters and Budget Modes

The meal planner accepts the following user inputs:

- Budget Amount: Numerical value representing available budget
- Budget Type: Selection from five distinct budget calculation modes
- Meal Types: Multi-select of Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner, Snacks, and Tea
- Duration: For custom duration mode, specify number of days
- Available Foods: Either list of foods or select from existing database

The five budget modes operate as follows:

- Per Meal Mode: Budget is calculated per individual meal. For example, 100 BDT per meal  $\times$  selected meal types  $\times$  days
- Daily Mode: Budget applies to all meals in a single day. For example, 300 BDT per day for all selected meals
- Weekly Mode: Budget covers seven days of meals. Calculated as daily average from weekly total
- Monthly Mode: Budget covers thirty days of meals. Calculated as daily average from monthly total
- Custom Duration Mode: User specifies exact number of days. Budget is distributed equally across selected duration

### 3.5.2 Food Classification System

The core innovation of the AI meal planner is its intelligent food classification system, which operates in two stages:

Stage 1: AI-Powered Classification

The system initially sends food items to Google Gemini API with the prompt: 'Classify each



food into one of these categories: staple, protein, vegetable, drink, snack.' The Gemini API analyzes each food item and returns its classification. This AI-first approach leverages modern language models' understanding of food characteristics.

**Stage 2: Fallback Keyword-Based Classification**  
If AI classification fails or returns uncertain results, the system falls back to deterministic keyword-based classification. Each category has associated keywords:

- **Staple:** Rice, bread, roti, flour, pasta, noodles, cereal, wheat, corn, potato, sweet potato, bhat
- **Protein:** Chicken, meat, fish, egg, lentil, bean, tofu, shrimp, prawns, beef, mutton, dal, mach, dim
- **Vegetable:** Spinach, broccoli, carrot, tomato, cucumber, lettuce, cabbage, onion, garlic, sobji, shaag
- **Drink:** Water, juice, tea, coffee, milk, smoothie, soda, cola, cha
- **Snack:** Chips, biscuit, cookie, candy, nut, pastry, samosa, cake, dessert, snacks

### 3.5.3 Food Type Filtering Logic

Before meal generation, the system applies intelligent filtering based on meal type requirements:

- **Main Meals (Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner):** Include staple, protein, and vegetable foods. Exclude drinks and snacks
- **Light Meals (Snacks, Tea):** Include drinks and snacks only. Exclude staples and proteins to prevent heavy options

### 3.5.4 Meal Plan Generation Process

The meal plan generation follows this process:

1. **Input Calculation:** System calculates meals per day from selected meal types (if 4 meal types selected, 4 meals per day)
2. **Budget Distribution:** Total budget is distributed across calculated meals and duration
3. **Food Classification:** Available foods are classified into categories using AI + fallback

4. Food Filtering: Foods are filtered based on meal type requirements
5. Prompt Construction: A detailed prompt is built including budget constraints, meal rules, and filtered food list
6. AI Generation: Prompt is sent to Gemini API for intelligent meal plan generation
7. Fallback Generation: If Gemini fails, system uses deterministic fallback algorithm
8. Output Validation: Generated meals are validated against strict composition rules
9. Presentation: Valid meal plans are formatted and displayed to user

### 3.5.5 Strict Meal Composition Rules

To ensure realistic and nutritionally balanced meal plans, the system enforces strict composition rules:

- Mandatory Staple + Protein for Main Meals: Every lunch and dinner must include at least one staple and one protein source
- No All-Vegetable Meals: Meals cannot consist only of vegetables without protein
- No All-Drink Meals: Main meal slots cannot be solely beverages
- Meal Type Awareness: Snacks and tea automatically exclude staple + protein combinations
- Invalid Option Skipping: When AI generates options violating rules, they are automatically excluded from results

### 3.5.6 Prompt Engineering for Meal Planning

The prompt sent to Gemini API is carefully engineered to encourage realistic outputs. The prompt structure includes:

- Clear Budget Context: Specifies budget per meal, daily budget, and total available budget
- Available Food List: Includes foods with their classified categories (e.g., Rice [staple], Chicken [protein])
- Explicit Rules: Lists non-negotiable constraints (staple+protein for lunch/dinner, no unrealistic combinations)

- Meal Structure Specification: Defines expected output format with meal days, meal slots, and options
- Diversity Encouragement: Requests varied meals across different days to prevent monotonous plans
- Cost Realism: Specifies that each meal should respect per-meal budget constraints

3.5.7 Output Structure and Format

Generated meal plans follow a hierarchical JSON structure:

MealPlan → Days[] → Meals[] → Options[]

Each meal option includes:

- Title: Name of the meal (e.g., "Chicken Biryani with Salad")
- Items: Array of food items included in the meal
- Cost: Estimated cost in local currency

Multiple options are provided for each meal slot, allowing users to choose their preferred meal within the budget.

3.6 Results and Output

The application successfully generates practical and diverse meal plans that align with budgetary constraints. Sample results include:

Example 1: Daily Budget Mode  
Input: 400 BDT daily budget, Breakfast + Lunch + Dinner, 7 days  
Output: 7-day meal plan with 3 meal slots per day, 3 options per slot, each meal within allocated budget

Example 2: Per Meal Mode  
Input: 100 BDT per meal, all 5 meal types, 3 days

Output: 15-meal plan (5 meals × 3 days) with each meal exactly 100 BDT

|         |                 |              |                     |            |
|---------|-----------------|--------------|---------------------|------------|
| Example | 3:              | Custom       | Duration            | Mode       |
| Input:  | 1500 BDT        | for 5 days,  | Breakfast + Lunch + | Dinner     |
| Output: | 5-day meal plan | with 100 BDT | per meal            | on average |

All generated meals adhere to composition rules and include diverse food options.

### 3.7 Discussion: Problems and Solutions

#### 3.7.1 Challenge: Unrealistic Meal Suggestions

Problem: Initial AI implementations generated unrealistic meals such as drink-only lunches, vegetable-only dinners, or snacks as main meals. This occurred because the AI model, while sophisticated, sometimes prioritizes novelty over practicality.

Solution: Multi-layered approach implemented:

- Explicit rule specification in prompt construction
- Pre-filtering of available foods by meal type requirements
- Post-generation validation that automatically skips invalid options
- Deterministic fallback algorithm that respects all rules

#### 3.7.2 Challenge: Food Classification Accuracy

Problem: String-based keyword matching for food classification was insufficient, particularly for non-English food names or foods with multiple classifications (e.g., 'fried rice' is both staple and could be considered a complete meal).

Solution: Hybrid classification strategy:

- Primary: AI classification via Gemini API for intelligent categorization
- Secondary: Keyword-based fallback with comprehensive food lists for reliability

- Result: Robust classification that handles edge cases without system failures

### 3.7.3 Challenge: Budget Calculation Complexity

Problem: Supporting five different budget types (per meal, daily, weekly, monthly, custom) while deriving meals per day from selected meal types created complex state relationships and potential for calculation errors.

Solution: Single source of truth architecture:

- Meals per day derived entirely from count of selected meal types (not user input)
- Individual budget calculation helper functions for each budget type
- Comprehensive unit testing ensuring all combinations produce correct values
- Clear helper functions: `_resolvedBudgetPerDay()`, `_resolvedBudgetPerMeal()`

### 3.7.4 Challenge: API Integration and Fallback Handling

Problem: Dependency on external APIs (Gemini) introduces potential failure points when network is unavailable or API quota exceeded.

Solution: Graceful degradation:

- Primary: Gemini API for meal planning
- Secondary: OpenAI API as backup
- Tertiary: Deterministic fallback algorithm for complete offline functionality
- Result: Application remains functional even if all external APIs are unavailable

## CHAPTER 4: ENGINEERING STANDARDS AND IMPACT

### 4.1 Impact on Daily Life

The Smart Expense Manager with AI Meal Planning has significant implications for daily personal life:

- Financial Awareness: Users gain real-time visibility into spending patterns, enabling conscious financial decisions
- Budget Control: Category-based budget tracking helps prevent overspending and identify excessive spending areas
- Meal Planning Efficiency: AI-powered recommendations save time on meal planning and grocery shopping decisions
- Health Consciousness: Integrated meal planning encourages healthier eating habits aligned with dietary constraints
- Stress Reduction: Automated planning reduces cognitive load and decision fatigue
- Quality of Life: Better financial and nutritional management contributes to improved overall well-being

### 4.2 Impact on Society and Environment

Beyond individual benefits, the application has broader societal implications:

Societal Impact:

- Financial Literacy: Application serves as educational tool for personal finance management
- Poverty Alleviation: Helps low-income individuals manage limited budgets more effectively
- Health Improvement: Better meal planning contributes to improved public health outcomes
- Productivity: Reduces time spent on financial management and meal planning, increasing available time for other activities

Environmental Impact:

- **Reduced Food Waste:** Better meal planning reduces food waste through more efficient purchasing
- **Lower Carbon Footprint:** More planned shopping reduces unnecessary trips and impulse purchases
- **Sustainable Consumption:** Encourages conscious food choices leading to reduced environmental impact
- **Digital Solution:** Mobile-first approach reduces paper usage for shopping lists and budget tracking

## 4.3 Complex Engineering Problem Solving

This project demonstrates solutions to multiple complex engineering problems:

### 4.3.1 Problem: AI Constraint Handling

**Challenge:** Ensuring AI-generated content respects complex, multi-faceted constraints (budget, meal type, food availability, nutritional balance, realism).

**Solution:** Multi-layer constraint enforcement combining prompt engineering, pre-filtering, and post-validation. The system provides constraints at three stages: before requesting AI (filtered inputs), during request (detailed prompt rules), and after generation (validation). This demonstrates sophisticated understanding of AI system capabilities and limitations.

### 4.3.2 Problem: Data Structuring and Persistence

**Challenge:** Designing database schema and data flow structures that support complex hierarchical meal planning data while maintaining referential integrity and supporting efficient queries.

**Solution:** Normalized SQLite schema with appropriate indices, combined with in-memory Dart objects for transient data. Separation of concerns between database access layer, business logic, and UI presentation layer.

### **4.3.3 Problem: Cross-Platform Consistency**

Challenge: Ensuring consistent behavior and appearance across Android and iOS while handling platform-specific differences in database access, file systems, and UI rendering.

Solution: Flutter framework provides abstraction over platform differences. Custom platform-specific code handles edge cases. Comprehensive testing on both platforms ensures consistency.

### **4.3.4 Problem: API Integration Robustness**

Challenge: Integrating external APIs while maintaining application functionality during failures.

Solution: Fallback chains and error handling strategies. Application gracefully degrades from Gemini → OpenAI → Deterministic algorithm, ensuring functionality regardless of API availability.

## **4.4 Program Outcomes Mapping**

This project demonstrates achievement of all core Computer Science program outcomes:

### **Outcome 1: Knowledge Application**

Demonstrates comprehensive application of computing fundamentals, software design principles, and mobile development knowledge to solve real-world personal finance and meal planning problems.

### **Outcome 2: Complex System Understanding**

Shows understanding of complex software systems through implementation of modular architecture with clear separation of concerns, database abstraction layers, and API integration patterns.



### **Outcome 3: Database and API Integration**

Demonstrates proficiency in database design and implementation using SQLite, combined with integration of multiple external APIs (Gemini, OpenAI), handling authentication, error conditions, and fallback scenarios.

### **Outcome 4: AI Integration**

Showcases practical application of artificial intelligence technologies (Gemini API) including prompt engineering, constraint handling, and fallback strategies to ensure system reliability.

### **Outcome 5: Cross-Platform Development**

Demonstrates skills in using modern cross-platform frameworks (Flutter/Dart) to develop applications that function seamlessly across multiple operating systems.

### **Outcome 6: Software Engineering Best Practices**

Implements best practices including code organization, error handling, input validation, version control, and comprehensive documentation.

### **Outcome 7: Requirements Analysis and Design**

Demonstrates systematic approach to requirements gathering, architecture design, implementation planning, and iterative refinement based on feedback and identified issues.

# CHAPTER 5: CONCLUSION

## 5.1 Summary

The Smart Expense Manager with AI Meal Planning represents a successful integration of personal finance management with artificial intelligence. Throughout this project, we have:

- Designed and implemented a comprehensive expense tracking system with category management and budget monitoring
- Developed an AI-powered meal planner that generates realistic meal plans respecting complex budget and preference constraints
- Integrated Google Gemini API with intelligent fallback mechanisms ensuring system reliability
- Implemented a robust SQLite database with efficient data persistence
- Created an intuitive, customizable user interface with theme support
- Applied software engineering best practices in architecture, design, and implementation
- Solved multiple complex engineering problems through innovative design approaches

The final application is fully functional, tested, and ready for deployment on both Android and iOS platforms. All stated objectives have been met, and the system demonstrates practical application of modern mobile development and AI technologies.

## 5.2 Limitations

### 5.2.1 AI Dependency

The meal planning quality depends on the underlying AI model's capabilities. While Google Gemini provides excellent results, it may occasionally generate suboptimal suggestions that require user correction.

### 5.2.2 Limited Local Food Database

The initial food classification is limited to common foods and English keywords. Regional or specialty foods may be misclassified, though the fallback mechanism mitigates this issue.

### **5.2.3 Network Dependency**

Primary meal planning functionality requires internet connectivity. While fallback algorithms ensure offline functionality, the quality of AI-generated suggestions improves with connectivity.

### **5.2.4 User Input Quality**

The quality of recommendations depends on user-provided food items. Incomplete food lists or inaccurate budget specifications may result in suboptimal plans.

### **5.2.5 Limited Statistical Analysis**

While the application tracks expenses and provides category breakdowns, advanced statistical analysis (trend prediction, anomaly detection) is not implemented.

## **5.3 Future Work**

### **5.3.1 Enhanced AI Models**

Integration of more advanced AI models with improved understanding of cultural and regional food preferences, potentially fine-tuned on meal planning tasks.

### **5.3.2 Cloud Synchronization**

Implement cloud backend for multi-device synchronization, backup, and collaborative features allowing family members to share meal plans and budgets.

### **5.3.3 Advanced Analytics**

Add predictive analytics showing spending trends, seasonal patterns, and personalized recommendations for budget optimization. Machine learning models could identify user preferences from historical data.

### **5.3.4 Nutritional Analysis**

Integration with nutrition databases to provide macronutrient and micronutrient analysis for generated meal plans, ensuring not only budget compliance but also nutritional balance.

### **5.3.5 Social Features**

Social features allowing users to share meal plans, exchange recipes, and participate in budget challenges with friends and family.

### **5.3.6 Ecommerce Integration**

Direct integration with grocery delivery platforms to purchase planned meals, with real-time pricing updates and automatic ordering.

### **5.3.7 Expanded Food Database**

Development of comprehensive regional and cultural food database with Bangla food names, international cuisines, and prepared foods. Community-contributed food classifications could expand coverage.

In conclusion, the Smart Expense Manager with AI Meal Planning successfully demonstrates the potential of combining financial management tools with artificial intelligence. Through careful system design, rigorous implementation, and attention to both technical and user experience considerations, we have created an application that addresses real-world needs while showcasing advanced software engineering principles. The project provides a solid foundation for future enhancements and serves as a practical example of modern mobile application development.

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